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Bureaucracy and Burden: Understanding Take-up of a Need-Based Financial Aid Program

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Abstract

Social programs, including college financial aid, often reach only a fraction of eligible beneficiaries. We examine this problem through the lens of Michigan's Tuition Incentive Program (TIP), a state need-based grant aid program. We conduct a large-scale mixed-methods study using data on more than 1 million Michigan public school students and 55 interviews with program administrators, high school counselors, and financial aid staff. We find that while one third of Michigan high school graduates are eligible for TIP, only ~30% of TIP-eligible community college students receive the aid, limiting its impact on affordability. We identify key barriers that shape take-up: the presence of administrative burdens and fractured and ill-defined administrative responsibility, which constrains the ability of front-line administrators to alleviate these burdens.

Keywords

administrative burden, college affordability, financial aid, mixed methods, postsecondary education

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Introduction

Government agencies in the United States distribute social welfare resources such as education, housing, and income to alleviate poverty and promote economic mobility. Extensive research has examined the allocation of resources in times when need outstrips supply (McCabe, 2023; Zhang & Johnson, 2023). However, less is known about the inverse problem: sufficient resources, but low participation in aid programs. While take-up rates vary across social programs, low take-up is a common problem across sectors. For example, some programs—such as Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) and Medicaid for adults—have take-up rates below 50% (Ko & Moffitt, 2022). This problem extends not only to classic poverty alleviation programs but also to college financial aid, which provides critical support for low-income students to access higher education.

States spent nearly $16.6 billion on college financial aid for the 2022–23 school year, with $10.3 billion allocated as need-based grant aid for low-income students, who face persistent college access and completion barriers (Ma et al., 2024; National Association of Student Grant and Aid Programs, 2023). However, for these programs to improve college affordability, aid must reach those who need it. Just as take-up rates vary across social welfare programs, they also differ across financial aid programs. Some programs, such as the federal Pell Grant, the Kalamazoo Promise, and the Pittsburgh Promise, have take-up rates at or above 75% (Bartik et al., 2021; Kofoed, 2017; Page et al., 2019). In contrast, programs such as the New Haven Promise and the New York Excelsior scholarship have take-up rates at or below 25% (Daugherty & Gonzalez, 2016; Scott-Clayton et al., 2022).

Research in behavioral economics, public administration, and education has investigated several approaches to increasing program take-up (Baekgaard et al., 2025; Bhargava & Manoli, 2015; Currie, 2006; DeLuca et al., 2023; Finkelstein & Notowidigdo, 2019; Manoli & Turner, 2014; Negoita et al., 2023; Page et al., 2026); however, why so many benefits go unused remains an open question. Further, much of the existing literature examines administrative burdens from the perspective of the beneficiary. A much smaller literature investigates the role of limited administrative capacity on access to benefits (Bell & Meyer, 2024; Perales-Fernandez, 2025).

Our study extends this literature in three primary ways. First, we investigate the phenomenon of low take-up in the context of financial aid for higher education, of which there is limited prior evidence. Second, we investigate administrative burdens faced by potential beneficiaries as well as the role of key administrators in hindering or facilitating access to benefits. Our focus on administrators allows us to document the uniquely complex system where federal, state, and local bureaucracies interact, but no one administrative actor has control over the whole system—complexities that are missed when looking at take-up only from the perspective of the beneficiary. Finally, we also add to this literature by employing a mixed-methods design, which allows us to triangulate mechanisms using both qualitative and quantitative data and present actionable insights for program administrators.

Using this framework, this study uncovers key barriers and mechanisms of program administration that shape access to a large, need-based state financial aid program:

Michigan's Tuition Incentive Program (TIP), for which approximately one third of high school graduates are eligible. TIP provides scholarships covering tuition and fees for associate degree or certificate programs at Michigan institutions to individuals who spend a portion of their childhood on Medicaid. Most college financial aid programs rely on complex and opaque formulas using information from the Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA) to determine eligibility after application. In contrast, TIP eligibility is categorical in nature, determined primarily by the number and timing of months spent on Medicaid in childhood, making it possible for students to know that they are eligible for TIP prior to completing the FAFSA and applying to college.

TIP provided more than $70 million to Michigan students in the 2021–22 aid year, yet little is known about program take-up and the complexities of its administration. To better understand who receives TIP benefits, we created a new dataset linking individual-level administrative data from three state agencies. This individual-level dataset, which includes all Michigan public high school graduates (n = 1,084,116 students across 11 cohorts from 2011 to 2021), allows us to produce the first descriptive estimates of program take-up. We extend these descriptive analyses using 55 semi-structured interviews with front-line administrators across relevant bureaucratic systems, including high school counselors, state program staff, and financial aid staff, to uncover barriers to aid access and to understand how and why these constraints occur. Together these analyses provide a comprehensive account of the mechanisms that condition TIP take-up.

Despite TIP's widespread availability and relatively simple design, we find that only 14% of eligible high school graduates receive TIP funding within 2 years of graduation. However, not all high school graduates go on to enroll in a qualifying college, where students actually can receive TIP.[1] Conditional on enrolling at an in-state community college, only 30% receive TIP funding.

We identify key barriers that play a significant role in shaping take-up. First, early notification is only useful if that information reaches students in ways that they can understand. Both the message and the messenger matter for getting information to students, and when front-line administrators are unaware of a student's eligibility, they cannot help students access aid to which they are entitled. Second, students with intermittent Medicaid enrollment have lower take-up, as do those in schools with fewer TIP-eligible students and lower poverty rates. Third, we find that completing the FAFSA may pose a barrier for TIP-eligible students in accessing aid, even though eligibility is determined through a separate process that does not require information from the FAFSA itself. Finally, we identify several administrative barriers—including seemingly mundane things such as computer system linkages and high school graduation verification—that are outside the control of students and high school counselors yet are correlated with take-up.

Overall, we find that front-line administrators serve as advocates, providing an important bridge between individual students and aid programs and reducing administrative burdens for students. Our interviews show the many hurdles that front-line administrators must navigate to connect students to TIP aid. Although low take-up is often framed from the perspective of the beneficiaries, these results shed light on the intricacies of policy implementation and the various responsibilities of administrators

who try to manage them—especially when these responsibilities are fragmented across administrative entities. This concept of fragmented responsibility extends the literature on take-up by providing insight into a process where there are no "bad actors" but instead an overly complex system that makes it difficult for administrators, even those with the best intentions, to help those they intend to support. This mixed-methods study builds on prior work on take-up of social programs by illustrating that both administrative burdens and the front-line administrators from multiple agencies who connect individuals to aid can be understood not as standalone hurdles or actors but rather as a part of an intricate network. Indeed, only by examining both administrative burdens, on the one hand, and front-line administrators, on the other, can we fully understand the problem of low program take-up. While we focus on a financial aid program in the state of Michigan, these findings also may extend to the other need-based scholarship programs that exist in nearly every U.S. state and many other social programs generally.

Theoretical Framework

Extensive research examines how policymaking and policymakers shape access to social programs (Bell & Smith, 2022; Currie, 2006; Ebenstein & Stange, 2010; Halling & Baekgaard, 2024; Herd & Moynihan, 2019; Ko & Moffitt, 2022; Lipsky, 2010; McDonnell, 2025; Page et al., 2020). This research identifies two key mechanisms that explain how program implementation affects access: administrative burden and front-line administrator discretion. Although financial aid programs differ in some respects from classic social welfare programs, they share many aspects regarding problems of incomplete take-up.

Administrative burden refers to the barriers individuals face in accessing the means-tested programs for which they are eligible. This includes the applications, requirements, and deadlines (i.e., *compliance costs*) as well as the informational barriers (i.e., *learning costs*) and social stigma (i.e., *psychological costs*) associated with receiving government benefits (Herd & Moynihan, 2019). *Program requirements* are policy choices designed to verify need and organize distribution, but they can prevent individuals from applying for and receiving funds (Daigneault et al., 2025; Deshpande & Li, 2019; Figlio et al., 2015), especially those most in need of aid (Bertrand et al., 2004; Finkelstein & Notowidigdo, 2019). Consequently, individuals and families may be unaware of available aid or face obstacles accessing it.

Reducing or eliminating administrative barriers to take-up can increase program access. For example, automating eligibility verification and simplifying benefit enrollment processes (Fox et al., 2020) or providing individualized assistance in navigating the administrative barriers increases take-up of these public benefits (Bettinger et al., 2012; DeLuca et al., 2023) as long as sufficient resources are allocated to these supports (Negoita et al., 2023). Less resource-intensive interventions such as implementing nudges and reminders that guide individuals through administrative processes (Barr & Turner, 2018; Hopkins & Dorion, 2024; Manoli & Turner, 2014; Page et al., 2026) and simplifying bureaucratic language or information structures also have been

successful at increasing access to benefits (Baekgaard et al., 2025; Bhargava & Manoli, 2015). For example, automated text-based nudges and chatbots can be useful in guiding first-year college students through completing administrative steps when they address time-sensitive tasks; however, both the message and the messenger matter for intervention success (Page et al., 2026). Universal programs such as Social Security, which have few administrative barriers, achieve nearly 100% take-up rates, reflecting the payoffs to minimizing administrative burdens (Herd & Moynihan, 2019).

Federal and state grant aid in higher education is no exception. To receive means-tested aid such as Pell Grants (Pell), students must complete the FAFSA, which until recently contained more questions than an average tax return and required disclosure of complex financial information (Dynarski & Scott-Clayton, 2007). Unlike tax returns, which are prepared by income earners themselves, the FAFSA burdens students with documenting information about their parents' finances that they may not know or understand, such as family income and debts. Estimates suggest that between 35 and 50% of high school graduates do not complete the FAFSA (Bird et al., 2021). Furthermore, low-income students are disproportionately selected for FAFSA verification, a formal process requiring institutions to work with selected students to confirm the information on their submitted FAFSA, further burdening both individuals and the institutions they are trying to attend (Oster et al., 2020). As a result, the FAFSA creates a major barrier to college access (King, 2004; Kofoed, 2017; Page et al., 2020). Studies estimate that FAFSA noncompletion causes college students to forfeit more than $5 billion in financial aid annually (Kofoed, 2017). Many state need-based aid programs also require separate applications or documentation to prove need and eligibility.

These factors underscore the importance of *front-line administrators*—the civil servants who are responsible for connecting individuals and families with programs for which they are eligible—in shaping access to aid. Scholars have long studied how these *street-level bureaucrats* (Lipsky, 2010) exercise discretion over resource distribution while managing work constraints. Because many social programs—including educational programs—are administered in a decentralized manner, individual administrators make key policy decisions about categorizing need and prioritizing cases (Bell & Smith, 2022; Watkins-Hayes, 2009; Zhang & Johnson, 2023). These individuals become critical junctures in policy implementation, and yet, in decentralized systems, front-line administrators' roles can be ambiguous. For example, Watkins-Hayes (2009) found that welfare caseworkers' professional identities shape their approach: Some functioned as "efficiency engineers" who guide and enforce regulations, whereas others act as social workers who support clients holistically, helping with both professional and personal barriers. Therefore, to understand the impact of administrative burden on take-up, we must consider the role of administrators in the process.

In education, front-line administrators at both high school and postsecondary levels shape student outcomes. At the postsecondary level, financial aid staff determine how to combine multiple types of aid—grants, loans, and work-study—into a single financial aid package. They do so based on their interpretation of financial aid packaging rules as well as students' tuition and fee bills to determine which aid should be used

and in which order. Therefore, although students may be eligible for a range of federal, state, local, or institutional aid, packaging decisions ultimately impact how much students will pay and who gets billed. Financial aid staff also may have discretion over how to package some types of aid, and not others, and how much to help students access aid to which they might be entitled.

High school counselors also influence college-going outcomes (Mulhern, 2023; Sattin-Bajaj et al., 2018), and they vary in their ability to navigate the administrative burdens they and their students face (Bell & Smith, 2022). In 2023–24, the nationwide average student–counselor ratio was 376:1, well exceeding the American School Counselor Association's recommended ratio of 250:1 (American School Counselor Association, 2024). A reduced counselor load is tied to an increase in college attendance (Hurwitz & Howell, 2014), as well as better support for low-income and racially minoritized students, leading to broader take-up of state and federal financial aid programs (Bell & Meyer, 2024).

Like other front-line administrators, counselors have ambiguous roles: They serve simultaneously as college advisors, compliance officers, academic support, and social-emotional resources (Blake, 2020; Sattin-Bajaj et al., 2018). Given these competing roles, the structural and resource constraints facing many counselors limit their ability to assist students with college financing, which may impact both the effectiveness and the equity of these programs (Blake, 2024; Negoita et al., 2023; Perales-Fernandez, 2025; Sattin-Bajaj et al., 2018). Nonetheless, some counselors expand their roles to connect students with aid and college opportunities (Sattin-Bajaj et al., 2018). Counselors often help students complete the FAFSA while navigating intricate institutional, state, and federal deadlines (Billings et al., 2022). Although they lack discretion over aid decisions, they serve as key touchpoints for students seeking college financing.

Empirical Case: Michigan's TIP

Introduced in 1987, TIP now funds more than 30,000 students annually. TIP is a *first-dollar* scholarship that covers tuition and fees for eligible students enrolled in associate degree and certificate programs. Many state and local scholarship programs are *last-dollar* programs, meaning that they only cover tuition not already covered by other aid. First-dollar programs such as TIP get applied to tuition first, freeing up other, more flexible aid (such as Pell) to be used for costs including housing, books, transportation, and food.[2] Therefore, incomplete take-up of TIP may result in students using up their more flexible aid (like Pell) on tuition and having to cover other expenses themselves or through loans. For example, in 2017, the average estimated cost of attendance at Michigan 2-year colleges was $14,600 for a student living off campus and $8,500 for a student living with family (U.S. Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics, 2017), both exceeding the maximum Pell amount in that year ($5,815). A student who claimed both TIP and Pell would have TIP cover tuition and fees (on average, $4,180) and then still receive Pell to cover other expenses,

ultimately paying very little out of pocket. Without TIP, the student would have substantial remaining uncovered expenses.

TIP presents an interesting case in part because it has many features of what is considered a model free-tuition program. Eligibility for TIP is determined using existing administrative data and is based on participation in Medicaid during childhood. Students who are enrolled in Medicaid for at least 24 months within a 36-month period between the age of 9 years and high school graduation are eligible for the program, and eligibility is automatically determined by the Michigan Department of Health and Human Services. Eligibility lists are relayed to the Michigan Office of Student Aid,[3] the state team that administers financial aid programs, which then notifies students of their eligibility by mail. Unlike many need-based aid programs, which require students to wait until after filling out financial aid paperwork and applying to college to learn how much they will receive, students eligible for TIP are notified as soon as they become eligible (sometimes as early as age 11 years) and do not need to recertify their eligibility each year. They can count on TIP for the duration of their studies.

Students can access their eligibility through the Michigan Student Scholarships and Grants (MISSG) website, the online portal for state aid in Michigan. High school staff also can access information on student eligibility in this portal, but only if they have a Data Use Agreement (DUA) on file with the state. Since 2013, the Office of Student Aid has employed outreach staff tasked with brokering connections with high schools and institutions of higher education and increasing the visibility of student aid programs.[4]

In addition to Medicaid coverage in childhood, a student must be a Michigan resident, a U.S. citizen or permanent resident or refugee, and not have defaulted on a federal student loan. Because we do not observe these other factors, we focus on the Medicaid component of eligibility to identify whether students are eligible for TIP, which is also the most binding requirement.[5] To receive TIP dollars, eligible students also must graduate high school by age 20 years and complete the FAFSA. The FAFSA is not used to verify need but is used to identify where students plan to enroll. Until 2021, eligible students also needed to complete a TIP application by the summer of high school graduation. Finally, students must enroll in a qualifying program at least half time within 4 years of high school graduation.

TIP covers tuition and fees for associate degree or certificate programs of more than 1 year at participating Michigan institutions of higher education. Most TIP dollars go to community colleges, although there are five 4-year colleges in Michigan that offer at least one program qualifying for TIP. There is a second phase of TIP that offers a small amount of funding for students enrolled in bachelor's degree programs, but this is available only after they have earned an associate degree or the equivalent number of transferable credits. Because the primary benefits are directed at community college enrollments, we focus much of our analysis on in-state 2-year college enrollees. More information on the program details is available in Supplementary Appendix B in the online version of the journal.

Despite its seemingly simple design and the efforts to address structures that might affect participation, TIP allows us to examine the intertwined roles of administrative burden, program administrators, and school counselors and the overarching influence

of institutional environments on take-up. We expect the substantial *learning costs* to impact take-up of TIP. Students may be notified about their TIP eligibility as early as age 11 years, which presents both an opportunity and a challenge: Early notification might allow students to plan for college early, knowing that their tuition would be paid for, but notification that comes too early also risks being missed or forgotten. This may be even more consequential given the steps required to qualify for aid, such as the FAFSA and the TIP application (the latter of which was required until 2021 and had to be submitted no later than August immediately following high school graduation). These *compliance costs*, including the FAFSA and the TIP application, also may represent administrative hurdles that depress take-up. Finally, administering TIP involves several bureaucratic sites responsible for information sharing, verification, and aid administration. These sites, and the administrators that work within them, will be the focus of our analyses.

Data and Analytic Strategy

This study employs a convergent mixed-methods research design, meaning that the qualitative and quantitative methods build on and inform one another throughout the course of the study. We initially collected and analyzed data using exclusively a quantitative methodology, which is common in convergent designs (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018), but subsequent cycles of analysis oscillated between the two methodologies in parallel in a "double helix" framework (Mendlinger & Cwikel, 2008; Reckhow et al., 2021). Both analytic approaches to documenting and understanding program take-up were informed by interviews with policy leaders, program staff, and the front-line administrators who interact with both the policy system and prospective program beneficiaries. The quantitative analysis and qualitative data collection and analysis occurred in tandem, allowing for iterative hypothesis development and testing. For clarity, we present these methodologic approaches separately below.

Administrative Data

Our quantitative analyses use several linked administrative datasets at the student and school levels. We use administrative data from the Michigan Department of Education and the Center for Educational Performance and Information (CEPI) on all Michigan public school students and schools since 2003. This dataset includes full K–12 educational records: test scores, attendance, and demographic measures (e.g., race/ethnicity, gender, and free-lunch eligibility). We paired these data with postsecondary enrollment and degree records from CEPI and the National Student Clearinghouse. To measure TIP participation, we use data from the Michigan Department of Lifelong Education, Advancement, and Potential on participation in all state-administered aid programs, including TIP participation and dollar amounts received. We also obtained data from the Michigan Department of Health and Human Services on monthly Medicaid, TANF, and the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) enrollment for all students in our sample. We estimate TIP eligibility based on whether an

individual has been on Medicaid for at least 24 months within any continuous 36-month window from age 9 years until high school completion. Finally, we merged school- and community-level characteristics from various state sources, including school location, enrollment, number of counselors, operating expenditure, and school-level demographics from CEPI and FAFSA completion rate and whether schools have data-sharing agreements that permit counselors to access aid eligibility information for their students from the Michigan Department of Lifelong Education, Advancement, and Potential.[6]

We limit analyses to students who graduated from Michigan public schools between 2010 and 2021; each cohort includes ~100,000 students. Our full sample includes 1,084,116 students across 11 cohorts, of which ~34% are eligible for TIP ($n = 365{,}623$) based on their Medicaid participation in childhood.[7] Our main outcome is receipt of TIP aid within 2 years of high school graduation.[8] We present descriptive statistics and TIP take-up rates for the full sample of high school graduates before narrowing our analyses to the subsample of high school graduates who enroll in community college within 2 years of high school graduation. Supplementary Appendix Figure A1 in the online version of the journal provides a visual depiction of this sample selection, illustrating that 38% of TIP-eligible high school graduates enroll in a community college. We exclude from our analysis the TIP-eligible students who do not attend any college within 2 years (38%) as well as those who enroll in 4-year institutions (24%).

We limit our main sample to TIP-eligible community college students because individuals can only receive TIP if they enroll in a qualified program at a participating institution. Therefore, including those who do not enroll in community college in our analyses could conflate barriers that students face in the TIP application process with other factors that affect student decisions about whether and where to enroll in college.

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics for the full sample of high school graduates, with columns showing averages for the full sample, TIP-eligible students, and TIP-ineligible students. TIP-eligible students disproportionately face economic disadvantage compared with the state average: They spend an average of 83 months on Medicaid (from the age of 9 years), 15 months on TANF, and 76 months on SNAP during childhood compared with 2 months on Medicaid (from age 9 years), 0 months on TANF, and 2 months on SNAP for TIP-ineligible students. Additionally, TIP-eligible students spend ~70% of their K–12 years eligible for free or reduced-price lunch compared with 20% for ineligible students. TIP-eligible students have lower college enrollment rates (62%) than ineligible students (78%).

Quantitative Analysis

We examine take-up using a series of descriptive statistics along with school-level regression models that examine the role of different attributes in take-up patterns. Our focus on school-level analysis is motivated by the main mechanism of interest in our paper: administrative burden in the take-up of TIP that operates primarily through school-level processes, such as counseling capacity and FAFSA assistance, rather than

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics of Quantitative Student Sample.

	Not TIP eligible		TIP eligible		Full sample	
Statistic	Mean	SD	Mean	SD	Mean	SD
Female	0.50		0.51		0.51	
White	0.83		0.66		0.77	
Black	0.11		0.27		0.17	
Hispanic	0.04		0.08		0.06	
Asian	0.04		0.03		0.04	
American Indian or Alaskan Native	0.01		0.02		0.02	
Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander	0.00		0.00		0.00	
Two or more races	0.01		0.02		0.02	
Receives special education services	0.07		0.12		0.08	
Composite SAT score	1,045	187.28	931	164.07	1002	187.29
Composite ACT score	21	5.08	18	4.47	20	5.06
Share of observed K–12 years of FRPL eligibility	0.20		0.70		0.37	
Total months on Medicaid from age 9 years	2.06	6.07	82.57	30.09	29.21	42.18
Total months on TANF	0.25	2.78	14.59	30.33	5.08	19.01
Total months on SNAP	2.15	10.25	75.92	61.23	27.03	50.50
Receives Pell within 2 years	0.12		0.27		0.17	
Enrolled in any college within 2 years	0.78		0.62		0.73	
Enrolled in a public 2-year school within 2 years	0.39		0.38		0.39	
TIP take-up within 2 years	0.02		0.14		0.06	
Total TIP phase I received within 2 years	$72.83	826.22	$696.50	$2,516.29	$283.16	$1,635.47
Total TIP phase 2 received within 2 years	$0.56	22.14	$7.31	$81.34	$2.84	$50.66
Observations	718,493		365,623		1,084,116	

Notes. TIP = Michigan's Tuition Incentive Program; SAT = College Board Scholastic Aptitude Test; ACT = American College Testing exam; FRPL = free or reduced-price lunch; TANF = Temporary Assistance for Needy Families; SNAP = Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program; Pell = Pell Grant. Authors' calculations using our constructed administrative data panel. "Within 2 years" refers to within 2 years of high school graduation. Medicaid, TANF, and SNAP participation are only measured while individuals reside within Michigan.

through individually observable interactions.[9] Further, many of the key measures relevant to administrative burdens (namely FAFSA filing rates) are observed only at the school level.

We estimate models that take the following general form:

$$y_{jk} = a + S_j\lambda + X_j\beta + \pi_k + \varepsilon_{jk} \quad (1)$$

where outcome y_{jk} is the school-level rate of take-up at school j in cohort k among students who were eligible for TIP and who enrolled in college; S_j is a vector of school-level focal factors, such as counselor ratio, location, and FAFSA filing rates; and X_j is a vector of school-level controls, including school demographics, institutional characteristics such as enrollment and expenditures, and school academic characteristics. although we focus our outcome only among TIP-eligible students so as not to conflate low take-up of TIP with low eligibility for TIP, we use school characteristics that encompass both TIP-eligible and TIP-ineligible students because the characteristics of non-TIP-eligible students—as well as those who do not enroll in college—still may impact take-up rates. π_k is a cohort fixed effect. We cluster standard errors at the school level to address within-school, across-individual, and across-cohort autocorrelation of factors influencing take-up. We view these analyses as descriptive rather than causal, representing correlations that highlight the circumstances under which certain patterns of take-up emerge.

Qualitative Data

Our qualitative analysis draws on semi-structured interviews with professionals responsible for administering the TIP program at each level: the state of Michigan's Office of Student Aid, high school counselors, and financial aid officers at postsecondary institutions. We also conducted interviews with key informants—including policy elites, elected officials, and state higher education policy leaders—who provided essential background information about the program's design, history, and administration over time. We used these interviews to inform both the design of the semi-structured interview protocols and our initial quantitative analyses; however, we do not include these interviews in our formal qualitative analyses.

Our analysis sample includes interviews with all eight staff members in the Office of Student Aid responsible for outreach to students, families, and high schools about TIP and other financial aid programs. We also interviewed 40 school counselors from high schools across Michigan and financial aid specialists at seven postsecondary institutions. Sampling and recruitment for the latter two groups are described below.

We recruited school counselors using a stratified sampling design with purposive groupings (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). This strategy ensured balance on key high school characteristics to capture the range of experiences typical of advising students about college access and affordability in Michigan rather than maximum variation of schools with rare characteristics. We excluded nonpublic schools, virtual-only schools, early middle college schools (where most graduates are not eligible for TIP having already earned an associate degree), schools with no TIP-eligible graduates, and the smallest quartile of schools by enrollment. We stratified the remaining 505 high schools across 12 groups using three variables: below- and above-median Black or Hispanic enrollment, the school's urbanicity (i.e., rural, suburban, or urban), and below- and above-median TIP take-up. We interviewed counselors in at least two schools within each of our 12 strata and conducted a secondary oversample of schools

Table 2. Characteristics of High School Counselors Interviewed.

Characteristic	Number	Proportion
Demographics		
Female	33	0.825
Male	7	0.175
Black, Hispanic, or Middle Eastern	8	0.200
White (alone)	32	0.800
Job role and educational experience		
School counselor	34	0.850
College advisor	6	0.150
Years as a counselor		
N/A (not a certified school counselor)	4	0.100
One	7	0.175
Two to nine	12	0.300
Ten or more	17	0.425
Years at current school		
One	9	0.225
Two to nine	18	0.450
Ten or more	13	0.325
Counselor observations	40	

Notes. Characteristics are self-reported based on a survey conducted at the end of each interview. "Not a certified school counselor" includes those we interviewed who were either serving as a college advisor through the Michigan College Access Network or otherwise fulfilling some or all the responsibilities of a school counselor without having a formal school counselor certification. Supplementary Appendix Table A3 in the online version of the journal shows the characteristics of the counselors referenced in the text.

in northern lower-peninsula and upper-peninsula regions that were underrepresented in our original sample. This resulted in a total sample of 40 high schools.

The counselor interview sample is described in Table 2 (counselor-level descriptives), with characteristics self-reported by each interviewed counselor. Thirty-eight percent of interviewed counselors are either the only counselor in their school or served as a counselor-like figure in schools without certified counselors. Eighty-three percent of interviewed counselors are women, and 80% identified as White alone. The schools we sampled from are larger and serve a slightly more advantaged population than the full set of schools in the state, reflecting our decision to exclude the smallest schools from our sampling frame (as reported in Supplementary Appendix Table A1 in the online version of the journal). Interviewed counselors work in schools across Michigan: 48% in northern Michigan, 33% in southeast Michigan, and the remainder in middle and western Michigan. These schools serve populations that are, on average, 49% FRPL eligible, 11% Black, 9% Hispanic, and 74% White.

We also conducted semi-structured interviews with financial aid specialists at seven postsecondary institutions, including community colleges and one Michigan public

4-year institution that offers associate degree programs. We calculated institution-specific take-up rates among first-year TIP-eligible students enrolled in qualified programs and then recruited staff members from at least two institutions in each stratum: low, middle, and high take-up.

The staff we interviewed all had job responsibilities that included administering state financial aid programs and worked at institutions that served an average of 366 TIP-eligible students per high school cohort (relative to a statewide average of 379, as summarized in Supplementary Appendix Table A2 in the online version of the journal). Institutions were distributed throughout the state, and interviewed institutions had similar average Pell Grant receipts and proportions of students who are first-generation college students to institutions statewide.

We interviewed program staff, counselors, and financial aid staff using semi-structured protocols designed to allow interviewers to take a secondary role in conversations led by those with the most relevant experience (Lareau, 2021). From recruitment through interview completion, participants understood that this project was not an evaluation of their work and that our reporting would not identify them or their institutions. This approach resets the power dynamic to position participants as experts and researchers as students, empowering participants to share honest experiences rather than responses they believe interviewers want to hear (Lareau, 2021). The interview protocols therefore center participant expertise.

The school counselor protocol covers the counselor's role in the school, additional support for student advising, approaches to advising students about postsecondary options, knowledge of TIP and advising TIP-eligible students, and barriers to college access generally and TIP access specifically. We also asked counselors to describe their school, postsecondary pathways, and community context. The financial aid staff protocol covers their knowledge of TIP, processes for packaging aid and advising students, and barriers they observe to students accessing financial aid for which they are eligible. As in the counselor interviews, financial aid specialist interviews centered practitioner expertise and covered aid packaging processes, office staffing structures, experience interpreting and implementing state aid, and program navigation challenges. Participants were offered a $50 incentive for participation. Interviews were audio recorded and transcribed verbatim by trained transcription professionals.

Qualitative Analysis

The qualitative analysis is iterative. Throughout the interview process, the interview team met regularly to discuss emerging themes and remaining questions. We began with thematic analysis of interview transcripts to develop hypotheses and a structured codebook based on overarching themes. We then systematically coded each transcript using qualitative data analysis software (i.e., MAXQDA), meeting regularly throughout the coding process to calibrate techniques and add in vivo codes as they emerged. Research assistants not involved in the thematic analysis coded a subset of interviews as a reliability check.

Using relevant coded segments, we identified support for hypothesized mechanisms contributing to TIP take-up and college attendance among eligible students and identified additional emerging hypotheses. We completed analytic synopses of each case to identify evidence (or its absence) for each hypothesis. Analysis of individual case synopses helped us understand circumstances that may contribute to findings in specific contexts. Cross-case analysis helped us understand the heterogeneity and prevalence of our findings. Most synopses were completed by research assistants who were neither interviewers nor coders, with several completed by two separate individuals as a reliability check. Names in the text are pseudonyms either chosen by participants themselves or chosen by the interviewers if the respondent declined to select their own.

We took several approaches to ensure the trustworthiness of our analytic methods. First, our coding was done by multiple members of our team, with regular team check-ins to ensure intercoder reliability. Further, all counts reported in the data were verified by a research assistant who had not conducted any interviews or earlier coding of the data. Many of our qualitative findings are triangulated using the quantitative data (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018), as we will describe in the "Findings" section.

Findings

By matching data from several different administrative data sources from across the state, our study provides the first descriptive estimates of eligibility for and take-up of TIP, which was not previously known, even to administrators of the program. Starting with overall take-up of TIP among eligible students, regardless of college enrollment, we find that only 14% of TIP-eligible Michigan high school graduates receive TIP aid within 2 years of completing high school (see Supplementary Appendix Table A4 in the online version of the journal).

Low take-up reflects not only administrative barriers to accessing funding but also nonenrollment in qualifying programs. Among TIP-eligible students in our sample, 38% enroll in a community college within 2 years of high school graduation (see Supplementary Appendix Figure A1 in the online version of the journal). After limiting the sample to those who do attend community college, we find that still only 30% receive TIP funding. This finding is surprising. TIP is a first-dollar tuition scholarship, meaning that all eligible students who enroll in qualifying programs should receive TIP to cover tuition.[10] It is puzzling that 70% of TIP-eligible students who enroll in community colleges do not receive this first-dollar scholarship, effectively leaving money on the table.[11] Although take-up rates vary year to year, this results in about $35 million forgone annually by some of the lowest-income college students in Michigan. For the remainder of the analyses, we focus on take-up among eligible students who attend community college in order to unpack the low take-up and understand the administrative processes driving incomplete take-up.

Figure 1 illustrates how TIP eligibility and take-up change over time. Both TIP eligibility and TIP take-up have both increased since 2010, with take-up ranging from ~25% in the first year of our data to 40% in the last year. This pattern is possibly due to

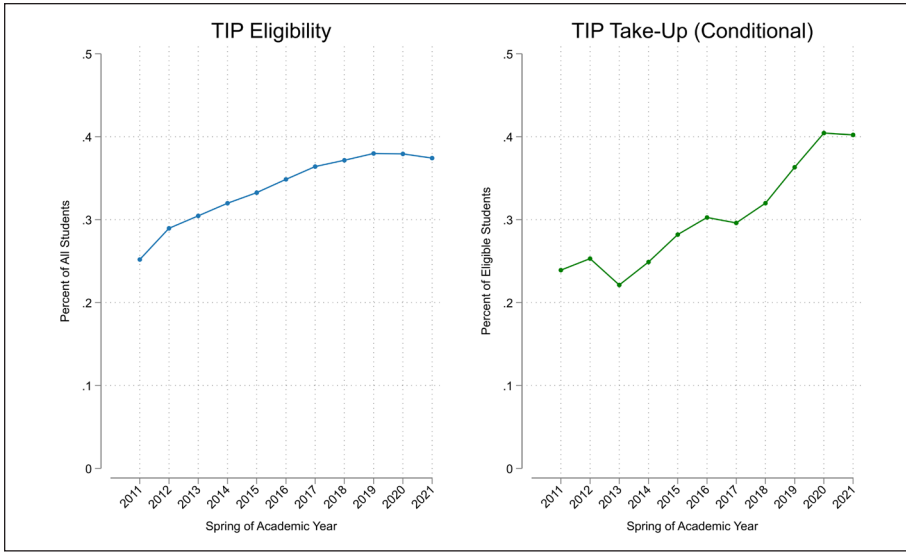


Figure 1. Michigan's Tuition Incentive Program (TIP) eligibility and take-up over time.
Note. This figure uses our constructed administrative data panel to figure report average take-up, calculated at the student level, for students graduating high school in each year. Take-up is defined as the proportion of TIP-eligible students who receive TIP aid within 2 years of high school graduation, conditional on enrollment in community college.

state efforts to improve take-up, including expanding outreach efforts to high schools and expanding access to data for financial aid offices, which we describe below.

We next describe the distribution of take-up across Michigan before examining potential explanations that predict take-up, including various sources of administrative burdens and bureaucratic hurdles students face.

Descriptive Patterns of TIP Take-up in Michigan

Take-up rates are generally similar by race and gender (Table 3, panel A). Females have slightly higher take-up rates than males, and Asian students have lower take-up than Black, Hispanic, and White students.[12] Perhaps counterintuitively, take-up rates tend to be higher among students with greater economic disadvantage. For example, TIP-eligible students who spend an above-median share of their observed K–12 years eligible for subsidized meals have higher take-up rates (37%) than those with a lower share (24%). Similarly, students whose duration on Medicaid is above the median Medicaid enrollment duration have higher take-up rates (37%) than those with lower Medicaid enrollment (25%).

These basic tabulations provide our first clue that more disadvantaged students might have better information about their TIP eligibility than eligible students who are slightly more advantaged. Conversely, we observe significant variation in TIP take-up

Table 3. Summary of Take-up Rates by Student and School Demographic Characteristics.

Characteristic	Conditional take-up rate
A. Student level	
Overall	29.9%
Gender and Race	
Male	28.0%
Female	31.5%
American Indian or Alaskan Native	34.3%
Asian American	19.5%
Black	29.7%
Hawaiian	29.5%
Hispanic	32.5%
Two or more races	36.6%
White	29.9%
Receives special education services	
No	29.6%
Yes	33.5%
Share of observed K–12 FRPL eligibility	
Below median	24.0%
Above median	36.6%
Total months on Medicaid (from age 9 years)	
Below median	24.8%
Above median	36.6%
Receives Pell within 2 years	
No	23.9%
Yes	40.3%
B. School level	
School urbanicity	
City	27.1%
Suburb	25.7%
Rural/town	40.6%
URM enrollment share	
Low	38.7%
High	28.6%
High school poverty enrollment share	
Low	32.4%
High	34.3%
FAFSA completion share[a]	
Low	39.4%
High	43.9%
High school DUA status[b]	
No	32.5%
Yes	45.1%

Note. FRPL = free or reduced-price lunch; Pell = Pell Grant; URM = underrepresented minority; FAFSA = Free Application for Federal Student Aid; DUA = Data Use Agreement. This table uses our constructed administrative data panel to report the average take-up rates across demographic groups at the student and school levels (conditional on enrollment in community college). Take-up is defined as the proportion of Tuition Incentive Program (TIP)–eligible students who receive TIP aid within 2 years of high school graduation. For school-level results, each high school is equally weighted when calculating the average. Medicaid, Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF), and Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) participation are only measured while individuals reside within Michigan.

[a]FAFSA completion share is based on 2019 to 2021 graduating classes only.

[b]DUA status was only provided for the academic year ending in 2020, so this tabulation reflects take-up differences for that 1 year.

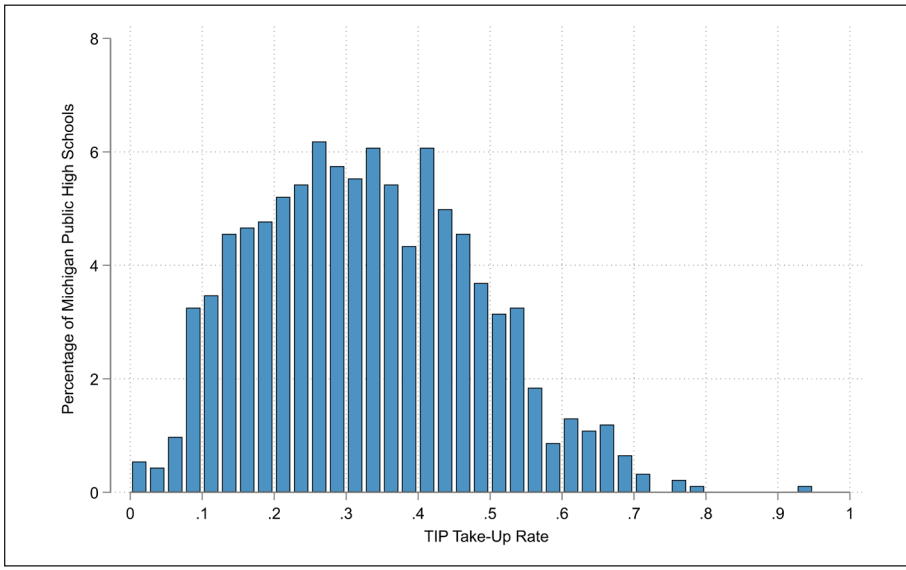


Figure 2. Conditional take-up rate by high school.
Note. This figure uses our constructed administrative data panel to report the average take-up rate for each Michigan high school in each year from 2011 to 2021. Take-up is defined as the proportion of Tuition Incentive Program (TIP)–eligible students enrolled in a Michigan community college who receive TIP aid within 2 years of high school graduation.

across high schools and across the state. Figure 2 illustrates high-school-level variation in take-up rates, which range widely from nearly 0% of TIP eligible students receiving TIP aid to nearly 80% of eligible students receiving aid in some high schools.

Michigan is geographically diverse, including rural districts in both peninsulas as well as urban and suburban districts in the lower peninsula (see Supplementary Appendix Figure A2 in the online version of the journal for a map of the wide variation in the distribution of take-up rates across the state). Table 3, panel B, reports conditional take-up rates at the high school level by school characteristics.[13] Rural schools have the highest average take-up rate at 41%, whereas suburban high schools have the lowest average rate (26%). Take-up is generally lowest in the southeastern part of the state, which is largely made up of urban (e.g., Detroit) and suburban areas. We return to several other school-level patterns in Table 3, such as the higher take-up at schools with higher FAFSA completion rates, when we discuss mechanisms below.

In the remaining sections we explore several mechanisms that might contribute to low and inconsistent take-up. First, we explore the information costs: knowledge of eligibility, whether students find out too early or too late for the information to be useful, and what school-level factors might improve take-up. Next, we explore the compliance costs: administrative hurdles such as the TIP application (required until 2021) and the FAFSA. Finally, we explore the hurdles faced by front-line administrators in trying to help alleviate these administrative burdens and distribute aid.

Inconsistent Knowledge of TIP Creates an Information Barrier

One unique feature of TIP is that students are notified as early as age 11 years that they are eligible for free community college tuition. When students become eligible, the state notifies them by mail. However, interviews with counselors suggest that the early notification process has limitations. Counselors reported that students often learned of their TIP eligibility during advising sessions late in high school, despite early notification. According to participating counselors, few students were aware of the program and their eligibility. When students had already heard about their TIP eligibility, the counselor then could explain what it means and how to ensure access. However, for most counselors, their conversations with students appeared to be the first time students heard about TIP, often not until 12th grade.

Leah is an experienced school counselor with more than 15 years at a large rural school with one counselor per 250 students. Approximately 35% of students at her high school are eligible for TIP; however, Leah estimated that only half the TIP-eligible students knew they were eligible before their senior year. She shared: "Of the half that know, a lot of them just don't realize what it all means. And I'm surprised [by] how many people are TIP eligible and just don't know." Khloe, the only school counselor in a suburban high school in the Detroit metro area, expressed similar sentiment. Thirty-three percent of students in her school are eligible for TIP, but she worries that many students do not realize the aid they are missing: "I feel like a lot of money goes unused, because you have kids who are getting this and they're like, 'Oh, I get this. Why do I get this or how do I get this?'"

Counselors speculated that the notification method, U.S. mail, was ineffective because students might not have received or opened the letter, did not understand or remember it, or discarded it completely. Janice is one of two school counselors in a midsized school in suburban western Michigan. She explained why students might not receive this information early:

> They should be getting notification via letter at home, but a lot of the students I work with didn't get the letter, moved a lot, or don't understand the letter. And so I pull students when I see that they're eligible to talk about it and talk about what that looks like.

Janice's thoughts were echoed by Nova, a first-year college advisor in a suburban high school in southeastern Michigan. Nova is a college advisor through the Michigan College Access Network (MCAN), which places recent college graduates in high schools for 1 to 2 years to support college advising. She explained that even if students receive the letters early: "By the time you're 18 years old and graduated high school, they don't know where that letter is or it's been [lost]." Several counselors stated that the notification letter may have added to parents' distrust because it was addressed from the Department of Treasury (which administered TIP until 2024) and embossed with the state seal. Nicole is one of two counselors in a suburban high school in western Michigan, where 37% of students are eligible for TIP. She explained why many parents or students may have ignored their TIP notification letter: "People were

throwing away that mail because they were afraid that the Department of Treasury was contacting them for something. So they just didn't want to see it, and they would throw it away."

As a result, counselors felt responsible for filling the information gap through various interventions, high-touch individual support, and advocacy—efforts often above and beyond the scope of counselors' primary duties. The majority of counselors (n = 31) reported talking with students individually about their TIP eligibility.

TIP's design around Medicaid poses a further challenge for identifying eligible students because student Medicaid participation is not readily available to school counselors. Unlike place-based financial aid programs, which rely only on where students live or how long they have attended school in the school district, or merit programs based on student grades or SAT scores, it is more difficult for counselors to readily observe TIP eligibility. Counselors can only obtain this information through a separate (i.e., MISSG) portal, which is only available for schools with a DUA on file. Thirty-five of the 40 counselors we interviewed were in a school with a DUA on file with the state at the time of the interview (see Supplementary Appendix Table A1 in the online version of the journal). However, because this process fell to counselors as another job responsibility, there was variation in when and how frequently they accessed TIP eligibility through the MISSG portal. Some were proactive in checking student eligibility early and notifying students as they became TIP eligible (n = 5). Others checked at regular annual intervals or once when students reached their senior year, giving students less information about TIP throughout their high school career (n = 15). However, even among counselors with portal access, many counselors lacked the capacity to proactively check it for students systematically.

Without these key data, counselors must rely more on contextual factors, such as their own knowledge of students' family circumstances, income, and background. This problem underscores the fact that early notification may not matter if front-line administrators do not know which students are eligible.

Timing of TIP Eligibility Contributes to the Learning Costs

TIP eligibility and notification timing may matter for take-up because students may learn either too early or too late about the potential to receive aid. Figure 3 illustrates take-up rates by total months on Medicaid since age 9 years (a measure of cumulative disadvantage during childhood) and timing of TIP eligibility and notification. We observe several patterns in this figure.

First, students who spend more time on Medicaid during childhood are much more likely to receive TIP aid relative to those who spend less time on Medicaid. For example, among students who just meet the minimum requirement for TIP (receiving Medicaid for 24 months), take-up is ~18%. In comparison, among students who spend essentially their entire childhood on Medicaid, take-up is double at ~37%. For students who have been on Medicaid consistently, eligibility may be less ambiguous both for themselves and for the school counselors advising them about their postsecondary options.

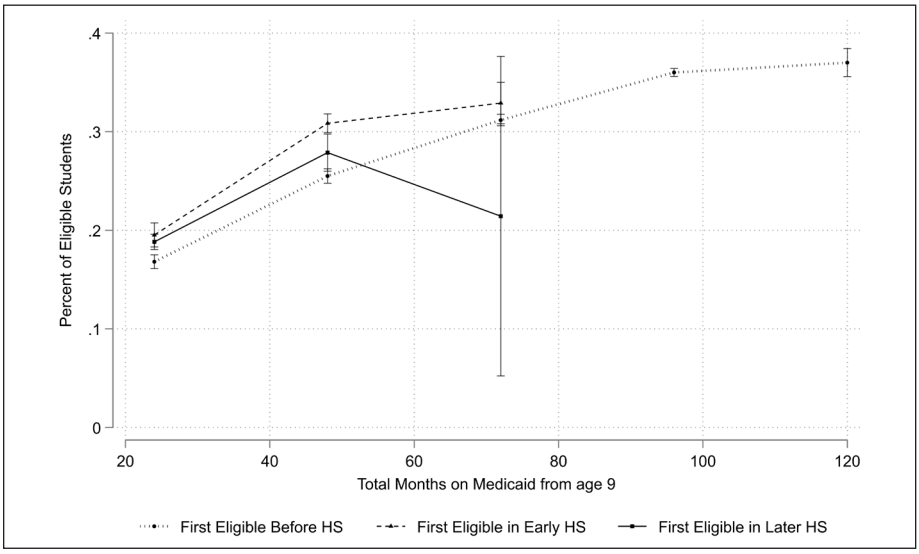


Figure 3. Variation in conditional take-up by total months on Medicaid and eligibility timing.
Note. This figure uses our constructed administrative data panel to report take-up, conditional on enrollment at a 2-year institution, by months on Medicaid from the age of 9 years, collapsed into 24-month bins (95% confidence intervals are represented by vertical bars). Take-up is defined as the proportion of Tuition Incentive Program (TIP)–eligible students enrolled in a Michigan community college who receive TIP aid within 2 years of high school graduation. Take-up rates are reported separately by the timing of when students first became Medicaid eligible for TIP, which requires 24 months of Medicaid enrollment during a 36-month window.

Second, we find that TIP take-up is highest among those who become eligible in early high school, whereas take-up is lower for those who become eligible either before high school or later in high school. This suggests that students may learn about the program either too early (likely before making college plans) or too late (when there is insufficient time to meaningfully change plans or orientations toward paying for college). This also aligns with what we heard from counselors. If students receive notification while they have access to a high school counselor with knowledge about TIP, they may be able to start having productive conversations about it throughout high school.

What School Contexts Help Overcome Learning Costs?

Table 4 includes results from school-level regressions that examine the association between school characteristics and take-up rates, as described by Equation (1). We view these analyses as descriptive rather than causal, illustrating important correlations between school characteristics and TIP take-up. We also acknowledge that there are many potential unobserved factors that could influence TIP take-up that we cannot control for in these regressions. Different columns illustrate different model specifications, progressively adding controls for student demographic characteristics and

Table 4. Regression Results Predicting School-Level Take-Up Rates.

	TIP take-up, conditioned on enrollment in a 2-year college			
Characteristic	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Share of students who are Black	−0.225***	−0.106***	−0.095***	−0.172***
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)
Share of students who are American Indian or Alaskan Native	0.072	−0.006	0.006	0.203*
	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.06)	(0.12)
Share of students who are Asian	−0.865***	−0.537***	−0.582***	−0.861***
	(0.11)	(0.09)	(0.09)	(0.15)
Share of students who are Hispanic	−0.058	0.05	0.041	0.127**
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Share of students who are eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	0.123***	0.134***	0.178***	0.251***
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.08)
Share of students who are TIP eligible	0.350***	0.261***	0.214***	0.185**
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.05)	(0.09)
School urbanicity, suburb		0.007	0.006	0.004
		(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)
School urbanicity, rural/town		0.116***	0.104***	0.106***
		(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
Log enrollment		0.007	−0.004	−0.023**
		(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Number of counselors per 200 students		0.021***	0.017**	0.019
		(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Share of students who complete the FAFSA				0.380***
				(0.07)
School-level controls	No	No	Yes	Yes
Adjusted R^2	0.134	0.162	0.167	0.183
Model *F* statatistic	63.249	67.575	42.762	28.965
P value on added variables	—	0.000	0.000	0.000
Observations	9,173	9,173	9,173	2,438

Note. TIP = Tuition Incentive Program; FAFSA = Free Application for Federal Student Aid. This table uses our constructed administrative data panel. Each column presents results from a separate school-level regression predicting take-up rates. Columns (1–3) include 2011–21, whereas column (4) includes 2019–21. FAFSA completion share is only available for 2019–21 cohorts. Take-up rates are conditional on at least part-time community college enrollment within 2 years of high school graduation. School-level controls include operating expenditures, mean SAT score, SAT missingness, high school graduation rates, high school dropout rates, and an indicator variable for whether the school is a charter school. Standard errors are clustered at the school level. Supplementary Appendix Table A5 in the online version of the journal includes the coefficients for all included controls. The *F* statistic for joint significance of demographic variables is significant at the 1% level across all specifications. Statistically significant coefficients are denoted with asterisks.
***$p < .01$; **$p < .05$; *$p < .1$.

school characteristics. Notably, coefficients are stable across models, providing reassurance that estimates are robust to the selection of covariates. We therefore focus our discussion on the model with all covariates and years (column 3).

First, both the fraction of TIP-eligible students ($\beta = 0.21$; $p < .001$) and the fraction of students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch ($\beta = 0.18$; $p < .001$) are positively associated with take-up and very large in magnitude: A 10 percentage point increase in the share of students eligible for TIP is associated with an ~2 percentage point higher school-level take-up. Counselor-to-student ratios also matter, where schools with higher counselor-to-student ratios tend to have higher take-up. An additional counselor per 200 students is associated with a 1.7 percentage point increase in take-up. This school-level analysis highlights the important role of school-level factors—the concentration of eligible students and counselor resources—in influencing take-up. These correlations also could reflect unobserved school characteristics such as school resources (although we do control for per-pupil operating expenditures), which might influence both the number of counselors in a school and TIP take-up.

These results support the evidence we have presented about the information costs associated with TIP. First, information and signals of eligibility are positively associated with take-up. As the number of TIP-eligible students at a school or the number of students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch rises, so does its take-up rate. This may be due to improved signals of eligibility because both students and counselors are more likely to be familiar with TIP aid if the program is commonplace or more students in the school are likely eligible. While suggestive, this is consistent with the idea that these characteristics improve the signal of TIP eligibility for administrators and teachers, improving their ability to provide pertinent information to students. Second, we found that counselors matter, possibly through reducing the compliance costs associated with TIP, which we explore further in the next section.

FAFSA and TIP Application Create Administrative Barriers to Access

TIP, like many social welfare programs, historically required an application (until 2021) in addition to the FAFSA. As with other administrative burdens, these requirements have the potential to dampen take-up among eligible students if students do not or cannot fill out the forms. Twenty-eight counselors perceived the FAFSA to be a primary barrier limiting take-up of financial aid. In many school contexts, counselors highlighted FAFSA completion as a challenge for students, and getting parental buy-in for FAFSA completion prevented some students from completing the forms.

Without parental consent, students cannot submit the FAFSA on their own, and without the FAFSA, students cannot receive federal or state aid. In many cases, counselors aimed to support students and families in meeting FAFSA deadlines. However, counselors often struggled to connect with parents around this issue or to advise students on complex family dynamics and social norms that shaped their parents' decisions. In fact, 22 of the 40 counselors we interviewed described encountering parental resistance to completing the FAFSA, which made it more difficult for them to help students complete that administrative step. Although this sentiment was shared among

the majority of counselors we interviewed, the explanations for this parental resistance varied across settings.

Counselors attributed some parental reticence to distrust of government. For some, this is a general sentiment about sharing information with the federal or state government. For example, Alexa, one of three school counselors in an urban high school in southeast Michigan, noted: "A lot of people don't trust the government. So, when you're saying that the government needs this information, it's already a barrier." Alexa went on to explain that some parents were concerned that the FAFSA was a means of stealing their identity or an attempt to fraudulently obtain financial information. "They think we're trying to steal their tax information and their identity when we do the FAFSA, so [they have a] whole bunch of just excuses to not do it. . . . They don't care or they don't think that's worth it or skepticism about the whole process."

In some school contexts, student and family immigration status shape FAFSA resistance. Tyler is an MCAN college advisor who had a 2-year placement in a south-central Michigan high school with two traditional high school counselors. He described fears among students with family members who are undocumented that filling out the FAFSA may place family members in harm's way or impact family access to resources. He noted:

> I have worked with several students mainly with our Spanish-speaking families who have undocumented parents or in different tricky situations. And I guess a lot of students are scared or scared for their families to even mess with FAFSA because in theory that shouldn't put anybody at risk, but I don't know what happens on that side and I don't know, that's always kind of a scary situation.

Completing the FAFSA not only allows students to access the TIP funding they are entitled to but would, in most cases, also give students access to Pell as well as subsidized loans. However, students weigh those benefits against their concerns about the potential for harm to their family.

Even when students attempt to fill out the FAFSA, counselors noted that students faced administrative barriers to accessing aid for which they are eligible. Counselors highlighted that even when they get students to fill out the FAFSA, administrative errors still get in the way. For example, completing the wrong year, mistyping their Social Security Number, or missing an item can leave their FAFSA incomplete. Unless their counselor is monitoring progress or they check to see if their FAFSA was processed (which most reported they did not have the capacity to do regularly, if at all), students may incorrectly believe that they have completed this step.

Other seemingly small administrative steps may prevent aid from reaching the institutions in which students enroll. For example, when students complete their FAFSA, they can list multiple institutions that they could potentially attend, which will then receive their financial information to complete an aid package on admission. However, until 2024, the office that administers state aid sent TIP eligibility information only to the first institution listed on a student's FAFSA. This means that if a student listed more than one institution and did not attend the first school listed, the aid

may never reach them. To correct this error, students must first be aware of the issue and then must call or log onto the state aid portal to notify the aid office that their institution should be changed. If counselors are not aware of this nuanced detail, or if the student changes their plans over the summer—something that is not uncommon—when they no longer have access to a school counselor, students might not know how to make this change.

Our dataset does not include direct measurement of FAFSA filings. However, we can observe Pell grant receipt, where FAFSA filing is also a requirement. Given the similarities in the average income profiles of those eligible for Pell and those eligible for Medicaid/TIP, we would expect significant overlap between TIP and Pell eligibility. When we condition our sample on Pell recipients (and therefore on students we know completed the FAFSA), take-up rates rise significantly (see Table 3). However, take-up is still far below 100%, with only 40% of TIP-eligible Pell recipients also receiving TIP (even though they all have already completed and filed the FAFSA).

We also have collected FAFSA filing rates at the high school level for 2019–21. In column (4) of Table 4, we see that the share of students who filed the FAFSA is one of the strongest predictors of school-level TIP take-up; a 10 percentage point increase in FAFSA filing at the school level is associated with a 4 percentage point increase in TIP take-up.[14]

The application requirements for the TIP program also may have lowered take-up among TIP-eligible students. Prior to 2021, students had to complete a separate TIP application to receive aid. Although we do not directly observe TIP application at the individual level, we can examine variation in the timing of the change in the TIP process to better understand if the application served as a barrier to take-up. In comparing cohorts before and after the application was required, we observe a large increase in take-up (see Figure 1), although the increase mostly occurred when the TIP application was still required. The average take-up rate for later cohorts (when no TIP application was required) is 40%; in contrast, the average take-up rate for earlier cohorts (when an application was required) is 29% (difference = 11 percentage points; $p < .001$). In sum, results on the FAFSA and TIP application suggest that burdensome paperwork and applications account for a modest share of incomplete TIP take-up but do not fully explain patterns of low take-up.

Fragmented Administrative Systems Inhibit Front-line Administrators

Although most studies of program take-up focus on the behavior of eligible beneficiaries, we find that many barriers to take-up are largely outside students' control and are driven by the complex interaction of several state agencies, high schools, postsecondary institutions, and program administrators. In the case of TIP, no one agency or administrator has full responsibility for administering the program. Further, the required data and information are spread across three different entities, none of which have regular or direct contact with the potential beneficiaries.

TIP eligibility is determined using administrative records maintained by the Michigan Department of Health and Human Services, which provides the lists of

eligible students to the Office of Student Aid, which conducts outreach to schools and students and higher education institutions, processes FAFSAs, and distributes aid to institutions. This means that information about TIP eligibility and TIP access involve integration of data systems across two state agencies and 31 public community college systems and a set of public 4-year institutions. Although high schools are not formally in this chain of administrators and often lack critical information regarding a student's eligibility for TIP, school counselors are on the front line and are responsible for ensuring that students know that they are eligible and how to access aid—especially if something goes wrong along the way.

High school counselors can only do so much to alleviate administrative barriers that may lead students to miss out on aid for which they are eligible. Due to policies on data privacy, access to the MISSG portal to view the full list of eligible students in each high school requires the school to establish a DUA annually with the state. Knowing who is eligible is essential if counselors are expected to communicate aid information to students, and whether the school has a DUA is highly predictive of TIP take-up (see Table 3). Furthermore, if schools have multiple counselors but only one is listed on the DUA, only the listed counselor will have access to the list of eligible students in the high school and whether they have completed all the necessary steps to access aid.

One role of the Office of Student Aid outreach staff is to establish and maintain relationships at the high school level to ensure smooth and consistent access to information. Andrea, a member of the outreach team, worried that information barriers for counselors might impact sharing of eligibility data:

> So what's happening among those counselors that are at the same school? Are they talking to each other? Are they like, hey, did you get listed on the DUA? Because we might only have one counselor, but maybe the other one should be listed. So it's like this continuing to spread the word, making sure that these new staff know about it.

Outreach staff wondered if inconsistent DUA status across high schools could be due to staff not knowing that it is an option. Ryan, another member of the outreach staff, speculated: "I'm like, we don't have all of our high schools participating and even accessing our system. So, why is that? Are they aware that the system exists? And if they are aware and they're choosing not to access it?" There are only eight outreach staff members for more than 1,000 public high schools in the state of Michigan. Therefore, the outreach staff often rely on existing relationships with schools or counselors, MCAN advisors, and presentations at state conferences for school counselors and college advisors to get the word out. This might create inconsistent access to information and support throughout the state.

After an eligible student enrolls at a community college, there is an additional set of data-sharing and administrative hurdles that needs to be cleared for institutions to apply TIP to a student's tuition.[15] First, institutions receive a list of students who are eligible for TIP (the *eligibility roster*). Financial aid staff members noted challenges with the online platform, including the complexity of the information they receive.

Financial aid staff explained that if a student does not show up on their TIP eligibility roster, staff have no way of determining TIP eligibility based on other financial information to which they have access. Financial aid staff would need the time, resources, and expertise to figure out who is eligible and contact the state to verify their eligibility. Jennifer, a staff member in the financial aid office at a Michigan community college with above median take-up among TIP-eligible students, explained how labor-intensive this manual process can be:

> But the state of Michigan has MISSG. It's their big system where [our state aid expert] receives [sic]; he can download a file from there and upload it into our system, and it looks at, you know, who is showing eligible for any of the state programs. And then it compares to our system to see who we already have an indicator for and who we don't, so he can add them to our student information system.

This often happens if students do not list their institution first on the FAFSA and do not go back into the system to rectify that. If students themselves do not know that they are eligible or do not know exactly what that eligibility should mean, they might not know to advocate for changes to their financial aid.

Further, just because a student is listed on the eligibility roster for TIP does not mean that their tuition can be covered by TIP. Before aid can be distributed (and therefore billed), institutions must verify that students have met all the requirements and are enrolled in a program that qualifies to be billed to TIP. They also must verify that a student is not eligible for one of the few financial aid sources that get packaged before TIP, such as private scholarships or institutional aid that can only be used for tuition. Mike, a staff person at one Michigan community college with below-median TIP take-up, highlighted this problem:

> [The online portal] is always going to have its issues. It's run by a third party; it's not even run . . . so it's going to be its own thing. . . . I would say the majority of the issue that we have to ensure is that sometimes general eligibility versus eligibility to be billed are two different things. So are they on the eligibility roster or are they on the billing roster. And so we have to reconcile that.

Before an eligible student can be awarded TIP, institutions need to verify a student's high school graduation. Officially, this happens through data shared by the state agencies that track education records. However, the administrative data are often not provided for all students; therefore, financial aid staff must work directly with students to get official documentation of graduation. Anna, a financial aid specialist at a Michigan community college with close to median TIP take-up, estimated that ~30–50% of TIP-eligible students in any given year need to manually verify their high school graduation status. This requires financial aid staff to track students down to get a physical copy of their high school diploma.

Institutions also must verify students' residence as well as their enrollment in a qualifying program (for enough credits). Financial aid specialists must navigate a complex set of program policies and regulations to determine who should receive aid,

which of their costs are eligible to be covered, and what aid should be packaged first. Although Pell and other federal awards are more automated based on criteria in the FAFSA, criteria for each different state aid program vary considerably. This requires manual verification to ensure that students are allocated the right amount of aid from each award bucket, a labor-intensive process. TIP, as well as several other programs in Michigan, is written into legislation. That legislation is then interpreted by program administrators, resulting in manuals for institutions on the policies and regulations that govern each program's administration. Andrew, a staff member of a financial aid office at a Michigan community college with below median take-up among TIP-eligible students, noted that these regulations change often and that the materials they have access to often report inconsistent information. He explained that figuring out the state prescribed application for each program is much more complicated than it seems: "I have to reference the state manual frequently. But yeah, it's all about untangling the rules and following them as they're written. Which, and they're not always super clear either."

The complexity makes it hard not only for financial aid administrators to get it right but also for administrators like Andrew, who pointed to this as a source confusion and uncertainty for students:

> These programs are a lot more complex than the billboard that says "free tuition" makes it sound like. There's one right out here by the highway that says "free tuition," and it's not wrong, but it's not entirely right either. There's a lot of nuance to these things. And students get frustrated and upset. That is a barrier too. The hidden complexity in this stuff is a barrier to students.

Discussion

This study examines the problem of low program take-up through the case of Michigan's TIP, a state grant aid program for which more than one third of high school graduates in the state are eligible. Like many social programs across the United States, most of the students who are eligible for TIP do not ultimately receive their entitled aid. Our mixed-method results reveal the complex relationship between administrative burden and the role of front-line administrators in shaping take-up patterns. Rather than focusing on take-up as an individual process, our analysis identifies the school- and administrative-level factors that are correlated with take-up rates and that shape the ability of front-line administrators to help students access financial aid benefits.

Program requirements are correlated with take-up rates, demonstrating how administrative burdens may contribute to low participation through both learning and compliance costs. Despite efforts to reduce the burden for eligible students as well as efforts to improve communication regarding eligibility, take-up rates remain low. FAFSA and TIP application requirements are modestly associated with lower take-up. Even something as seemingly innocuous as requiring high school graduation by age 20 years may create a barrier because it can trigger a manual verification process when data systems are fragmented.

At the school level, TIP take-up rates increase as signals of eligibility rise—specifically as the proportion of TIP-eligible or low-income students increases. This diverges from some of the current literature, which finds that street-level bureaucrats have less of an impact in schools with higher concentrations of low-income students (e.g., Bell & Smith, 2022). This suggests that an underappreciated aspect of administrative burden is the ability of front-line administrators to easily identify eligible students and target resources and (accurate) information. Most studies find that schools with a higher concentration of low-income students have reduced front-line administrator capacity, and this is certainly the case in our setting. However, in schools where most students are eligible for TIP, state agencies may be better able to target support resources and front-line school administrators to more easily share information about aid.

Our results illuminate a complex matrix of forces influencing take-up. Program design and administrative hurdles create substantial challenges for individuals seeking support. Although no singular barrier explains low take-up, multiple pathways exist for students to fall through the cracks, and these cumulative barriers may add up. Front-line administrators, including school counselors and financial aid staff, function not as standalone barriers but as components of an intricate network shaping resource access. The unique administrator perspective provided here presents an alternative picture of administrative burdens: those where administrative actors are not barriers to be overcome but key resources operating withing a complex system who could improve take-up if given the right tools. Institutional support can mitigate barriers, but only when staff possess the information, resources, and institutional knowledge necessary to provide consistent and informed assistance.

High school counselors play a pivotal role in shaping take-up for both individual students and entire schools. Although they face their own administrative burdens alongside their students, counselors can alleviate student barriers through mechanisms such as DUAs, which streamline the identification of TIP-eligible students and completion of required forms. However, counselors' roles in this process remain ill-defined and inconsistent. Outreach staff at the Office of Student Aid attempt to address these gaps by conducting school visits, helping establish DUAs, and building relationships with high school counselors, but with limited capacity; they often rely on existing relationships or counselor-initiated contact, potentially contributing to inequality. This aligns with findings in other settings that shifting responsibility from the state to non-state actors (such as school counselors or other front-line administrators) only works if it does not increase complexity or reduce administrative capacity (e.g., Negoita et al., 2023). Further, high school counselors cannot resolve administrative barriers that prevent students from receiving aid once they enroll in community college. Although decentralized administration of programs often gives administrators discretion over service delivery, in this case, fragmented responsibility for information delivery and administrative assistance leaves gaps in administrative support. It is not only the case that front-line administrators shift responsibility to avoid blame or burden (Seim, 2017), but fragmented policy administration also results in confusion, misplaced responsibility, and gaps in beneficiary support.

This research has several limitations that are important to consider when interpreting these results and provide avenues for future work. First, this research focused on administrative systems responsible for connecting students with aid but does not yet account for the experiences of eligible beneficiaries. On the one hand, our data are well suited for evaluating barriers to access on the administrative side of the process. However, the barriers and program limitations identified by program administrators and school counselors may miss additional barriers faced by students. Future work will examine how TIP influences student decision making through qualitative interviews with TIP-eligible high school and community college students.

Second, this study could not identify additional aid sources students receive beyond TIP, such as institutional aid, private scholarships, and promise program grants, and Pell eligibility is not measured. Prior work has shown important interactions between programs, such as when Pell eligibility crowds in institutional and state aid (Denning et al., 2019) in some settings and not in others (Eng & Matsudaira, 2021). Place-based promise programs also appear to increase federal student aid (Sotherland, 2025). These interactions could explain some of the incomplete take-up, but we are unable to quantify them directly. Through qualitative student interviews, we hope to identify other aid sources and examine how TIP interacts with these other sources to shape postsecondary decisions.

Third, by conditioning our analyses on students who have already enrolled in community college, we may miss how TIP shapes community college enrollment itself. The factors that are associated with take-up of TIP might be different for these students than for students who do not to enroll in college. We examine these additional questions in ongoing research. Although behavioral economics has largely investigated interventions to improve information delivery to eligible beneficiaries, future work should investigate ways to improve access to information not only for eligible beneficiaries but also for front-line administrators tasked with translating information about benefits to eligible beneficiaries.

Finally, given the timing of our interviews, the qualitative data may understate the barriers experienced earlier in the period included in the quantitative analysis. Further, as we were completing the study, Michigan underwent several changes to the financial aid landscape, introducing new, less comprehensive but wider-reaching community college tuition grants that may change not only college affordability but also access to other programs. Given the timing, we were unable to observe how these changes may have impacted TIP take-up and the take-up of other financial aid. Future work should investigate how these policy changes shaped access to TIP and other financial aid programs in the state.

This research contributes to our understanding of the role of administrative burden (Herd & Moynihan, 2019) and street-level bureaucrats (Lipsky, 2010) in shaping take-up (Currie, 2006; Ko & Moffitt, 2022). Our mixed-methods study design provides a comprehensive investigation of factors predicting take-up, with implications extending beyond the TIP program to other financial aid and social programs with low participation rates. This work highlights the value of mixed-methods research to identify mechanisms and quantify them in order to paint a more comprehensive picture of

program design and take-up. For example, the New York Excelsior and the New Haven Promise have take-up rates in similar ranges to the TIP program (Daugherty & Gonzalez, 2016; Scott-Clayton et al., 2022); from a policy perspective, our results shed light on mechanisms that could boost take-up among eligible students. Programs that have much higher participation, such as the Kalamazoo or Pittsburgh Promise, do not have the same administrative hurdles and lack of clarity about eligibility that characterize TIP. Individual behavioral solutions to increasing take-up, many of which had already been implemented in our context, can only go so far when front-line administrator capacity is limited and responsibility for providing information about and administering aid is fragmented. This work underscores the importance of considering both policy design and implementation, beyond relying on individual actors—such as front-line administrators—to alleviate system-level burdens.

Author Note

Nathan Sotherland coauthored this paper before joining Cornerstone Research. The views expressed herein are solely those of the authors, who are responsible for the content and do not necessarily represent the views of Cornerstone Research.

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Ethical Considerations

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The authors declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Data Availability Statement

This research used data structured and maintained by the MERI–Michigan Education Data Center (MEDC). MEDC data are modified for analysis purposes using rules governed by the MEDC and are not identical to those data collected and maintained by the Michigan Department of Education (MDE) and/or Michigan's Center for Educational Performance and Information (CEPI).

Supplemental Material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

Notes

1. Most social benefits require two steps. First, an individual must be eligible based on criteria set by policy or program administers (i.e., *eligible*). Second, an eligible individual must complete steps to qualify for benefits including application, verification, work requirements (i.e., *qualified*). In the TIP context, *eligibility* refers to participation in Medicaid for 24 months within a 36-month period, whereas *qualified* refers to eligible students who meet the requirements to receive funds, such as completing the FAFSA and enrolling in a qualifying program.
2. TIP being applied for before the Pell Grant is what distinguishes it from most other free college plans. There are a few other first-dollar place-based or institutional scholarships that can be applied before TIP, but these are relatively uncommon.
3. Until recently, this work was done by the Michigan Office of Student Aid in the Michigan Department of Treasury. Recently, this work was moved to the newly formed Office of Higher Education in the Michigan Department of Lifelong Education, Advancement, and Potential. Given the timing of our study, we continue to refer to this office as the Office of Student Aid.
4. Since 2013, the outreach team has expanded from one staff member to a team of 10, including six staff members working directly with schools across the state.
5. According to the American Community Survey, 96% of adults in the state of Michigan were citizens. We therefore do not think that lack of citizenship is a primary reason why some individuals do not take up TIP. We also limit our sample to high school graduates who enroll in community college within 2 years of completing high school; it is highly unlikely that any of these students would have defaulted on a student loan.
6. We only have information on data-sharing agreements for the 2019–20 school year.
7. A small number of students who appear TIP ineligible are observed receiving TIP. This could result from errors in the matching procedure used to link data sources or appeals/petitions related to eligibility that we do not observe.

8. We specify a 2-year time frame to maintain consistency with prior literature analyzing college enrollment and to evaluate take-up within a consistent time frame for individuals graduating across more than 10 years. Focusing on a 1-year window would exclude a nontrivial share of eventual enrollees. For example, TIP take-up in our data is 11.5% within 1 year of graduation, rises to 14% within 2 years, and remains stable thereafter. Extending the outcome window for earlier cohorts does not materially change estimated take-up.
9. We also completed analyses at the student level, which illustrate qualitatively similar patterns. These results are available in Supplementary Appendix Table A6 in the online version of the journal.
10. As described earlier, there are a few forms of aid that are packaged before TIP to pay for tuition. These programs are relatively infrequent, so they cannot explain the low conditional take-up.
11. Students not enrolled in at least 6 credits are also not qualified, but this only explains a small part of the remaining gap, and failure to enroll at least part time we view as one of the ways that low take-up materializes.
12. Lower take-up among Asian students may be due in part to smaller sample sizes generating a noisier rate because $<3\%$ of TIP-eligible students identify as Asian.
13. In a separate paper, we examine whether TIP itself affects the decision on whether and where to enroll in college. In Supplementary Appendix Table A4 in the online version of the journal we report take-up rates by student- and school-level characteristics that are not conditioned on community college enrollment. The general patterns we describe here are similar between conditional and unconditional take-up rates.
14. We note, however, that even with all the controls in the model, our regressions only explain $<20\%$ of the variation in school-level TIP take-up. This suggests that much of the variation in TIP take-up across schools is unexplained. There are a number of factors that might contribute to this unexplained variation, including unmodeled TIP knowledge at the individual or counselor level and variation in community college advertising or packaging decisions, among other things.
15. Supplementary Appendix Figure A3 in the online version of the journal shows the distribution of take-up at the community college level.

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